And yet, in fact, one in twenty-five people killed by the state were innocent. Under conditions of low state capacity, this error rate is likely to be higher. Death cannot be undone. We in India should be even more hesitant about the death penalty as compared with thinkers in the US.

Where is greater reversibility found? The presence of measurement systems helps. If an action yields an impact that can be well measured, there is a better chance of seeing a mistake and reversing it. In contrast, when measurement systems are absent, policymaking is fraught with greater risk.

The distinction between ‘first-generation reforms’ (stroke-of-the-pen reforms) versus ‘second-generation reforms’ (those that involve establishing complex government organizations) is useful here. It may be possible to reverse first-generation reforms, when it is understood that there was a mistake. It is harder to close down a bureaucracy once it has been created. Second-generation reforms are more irreversible.

Irreversibility is thus inherent to some things (e.g., death of a person), is greater when measurement is lacking, and is greater when the action involves establishing an implementation structure in government. These are the areas where greater caution is required in state intervention.

Summing up

There are no silver bullets. The reforms that matter are complex multi-year journeys that require a large policy community.

Participatory policymaking works better than small groups working in secret.

The ideal mechanism is to have measurement systems, and make small moves. Based on the feedback from the measurement, the small moves can be refined and modified as part of a larger strategy.

Do things that you can undo.

Beware of the things that you cannot undo. When the measurement is weak, mistakes will not be caught, and there is a need for greater caution. Stroke-of-the-pen reforms are easier to reverse, but when a government